The Quest Wilderness Ministry

Program Research and Planning Guide

The Quest Wilderness Ministry: Program Research and Planning Guide

A survey of existing programs that combine outdoor adventure, role-playing games (tabletop D&D or live-action role-play), and character formation. Prepared as background research for The Quest, a proposed program that takes young people on a backpacking or bikepacking trip where a hired game master turns the whole journey into one live-action D&D campaign.

Summary finding: No program found does exactly what The Quest proposes: a multi-day, moving expedition where the real miles, weather and fatigue become part of a single continuous campaign. Existing programs are almost all day camps or base camps, where the journey is imaginary and the setting is a park or campsite. The examples below each cover part of the idea.

1. Dust & Tribe — D&T Guild: Dungeons and Dragons Campout

Why it matters: Closest in spirit. A faith-community outdoor organization that pairs D&D with camping.

What it is:

- A weekend campout (example dates: August 1–3) priced at $430.
- Open to men and women 13+; "All creeds welcome."
- Rated "Adventure Score: 2" on the organization's difficulty scale.
- Held at D&T Camp One, with two nights of accommodation and four hosted halal meals (dinners and breakfasts).
- Format: a hosted dinner over an open fire, then an outdoor role-playing adventure; the next morning, a farewell breakfast and a local hike with the Camp One goats.

Gap relative to The Quest: Base-camp format, short duration, the game is an evening activity rather than the structure of the whole trip.

Links:

- D&T Guild D&D Campout event page: https://dustandtribe.com/?p=6333
- Related campout itinerary page: https://dustandtribe.com/?p=7627

2. AYF Camp Miniwanca — Worlds of Adventure: LARP and Dungeons & Dragons

Why it matters: Closest match on the character-building side. AYF (American Youth Foundation) is a long-standing character and leadership development organization.

What it is:

- Run within Miniwanca's Boys Camp (Michigan), reported July 2025.
- Combined live-action role-play and tabletop D&D.
- When a character died, players had to adapt, create a new character, and re-enter the world.
- A standout moment: the Boys Camp Director stepped in as a surprise villain, showing staff acting directly inside the fiction.

Gap relative to The Quest: Takes place at a resident camp, not on an expedition.

Link:

- AYF article: https://ayf.com/?p=37893

3. Strathcona County (Alberta) — Nature's Quest: D&D and outdoor camp weeks

Why it matters: A public recreation program that pairs D&D with wilderness skills, and in some weeks a backcountry overnight.

What it is:

- "Nature's Quest: D&D" for ages 10–13: "Let the quest begin! We are waiting for you to join the Dungeon Masters who are ready to take you on a unique adventure."
- Camp listings describe playing a cooperative, strategy-based fantasy role-playing game where campers take on characters to complete a quest, alongside regular camp activities.
- No prior D&D experience required; basics are taught.
- Related weeks in the same program include fire cooking, wilderness skills, indoor rock climbing, and an overnight hike into the backcountry.
- Based at the county's wilderness centre.

Gap relative to The Quest: D&D and the backcountry overnight are parallel activities, not a single integrated campaign.

Links:

- Week 3 listing (Nature's Quest: D&D): https://reconline.strathcona.ca/STRATHCONA/public/category/browse/PROGOUTDOORX905SCWEEK3
- Week 4 listing (role-playing description): https://reconline.strathcona.ca/STRATHCONA/public/category/browse/PROGOUTDOORX905SCW4
- Week 6 listing: https://reconline.strathcona.ca/STRATHCONA/public/category/browse/PROGOUTDOORX905SCW6

4. The Story School — Camp FABLE and Camp Grimoire

> We aim to give our campers an inclusive, interactive, and immersive adventure. Our camp allows our participants to become their best selves through storytelling, role-playing, and teamwork. We believe there is a hero waiting to be discovered inside everyone. Nestled in the woods of Massachusetts, The Story School has the grounds and accommodations to make every camper feel safe and ready for adventure. At The Story School we encourage campers to become the hero inside of themselves through immersive storytelling and roleplay. All challenges and quests ask campers to be supportive, creative, and unique selves while also utilizing their STEAM skills. Campers find a deep sense of belonging at The Story School, often making lifelong friends. Many campers return year after year to be part of our live-action role-playing community.

Why it matters: Overnight, woods-based educational LARP ("eduLARP") camps, including a teen session.

What it is:

- Located at Nature's Classroom in Charlton, MA, on the outskirts of Boston.
- Camp FABLE: two-week all-ages sessions for ages 8–17, $3,600.
- Camp Grimoire: one-week teen session for ages 14–18, $1,900.
- Activities: LARP adventures, hiking, STEAM lessons, escape rooms, arts and crafts.
- Limited scholarships plus sibling and multi-session discounts; registration opens January 1.
- Directors: Laura Hall and Chris Wiley. Phone: 781-214-1174.
- Also runs online events.

Gap relative to The Quest: Resident camp rather than a traveling expedition.

Links:

- Program listing: https://finditcambridge.org/programs/story-school-overnight-fantasy-camp
- K12 Academics affiliate announcement: https://archive.benchmarkemail.com/k12academics/newsletter/The-Story-School-Affiliate-Message

5. Renaissance Adventures — Adventure Quest (Boulder, Colorado)

Why it matters: The best model for the live-action game master role, and for deliberately building moral dilemmas into play.

What it is:

- Summer day camps for ages 6–17 in which kids play heroes with foam swords on weeklong quests in local parks and trails.
- "Quest leaders" supervise each group and act as the link between the kids and the world, describing what they see and acting out what they encounter, while kids keep total freedom in their in-game choices, with real consequences.
- Director Mark Hoge: "We put all sorts of challenges into the quest—social challenges, moral dilemmas… Underneath it all we get to help them learn."
- Program variants: Star Quest (sci-fi), Quest and Quill (questing plus creative writing), and Heroes Academy (more in-depth, open-ended questing for teens).
- Teens can attend quest-leading workshops and become Counselors-in-Training.
- Safety is addressed first in each session.

Gap relative to The Quest: Day-camp format; quests happen in local parks rather than on a multi-day route.

Links:

- Boulder Weekly feature: https://archives.boulderweekly.com/?p=65125
- Yellow Scene camp guide feature: https://yellowscene.com/2014/03/20/summer-camp-guide/3/
- RPG Research provider listing: https://w3.rpgresearch.com/community/worlwide-list-of-providers/renaissance-adventures

6. Other related programs

- **Waynflete D&D Maine Adventure Camp (Portland, ME):** grades 4–9, about $375–$445 a week. Each day the campaign moves to a new outdoor location (beach, rocky shore, city park, fort ruins), with dice, DMs and bus transport provided. https://summer.waynflete.org/summer-camps/dungeons-dragons-camps

- **Epic Quest Camp (Eugene, OR):** mixes live-action role-play with wilderness skills; campers create a fantasy character and set off with an adventuring party. https://www.active.com/eugene-or/arts-and-crafts/camp/epic-quest-camp-2024
- **Cincinnati Parks D&D Nature Camp:** grades 4–6; a D&D one-shot tied to nature-themed activities, habitats and animals. https://cincyweb.cincinnati-oh.gov/cincyparks/visit-a-park/parks-events-calendar/dungeons-and-dragons-nature-camp
- **Heroes Academy LARP Day Camp (with St. John's summer programs):** grades 4–9. https://summeratstjohns.org/summer_programs/kids-larp-summer-camp/
- **Pali Adventures (California):** an overnight camp combining LARP, D&D and camp teamwork. https://paliadventures.com/?p=2613
- **Boardwalk Board Game Lounge D&D Summer Adventure Camp (Peterborough, ON):** designed partly from the co-owner's background as an outdoor educator, with an emphasis on teamwork and real-life skills. https://www.ptbocanada.com/journal/boardwalk-board-game-lounge-taking-kids-on-imaginative-journey-this-summer-with-dungeons-dragons-camp

7. Adjacent fields worth borrowing from

- **Wilderness therapy:** JMU's Counseling Center and UREC run trips where students backpack and take part in outdoor education sessions and therapy process groups along the way. https://jmu.edu/counselingctr/services/wilderness-therapy.shtml
- **Therapeutic role-play:** Vassar's "Dungeons and Therapy" group has participants embody their ideal self through a fictional persona. https://offices.vassar.edu/counseling-service/services/group-counseling/dungeons-and-therapy/
- **Wilderness travel rules for game masters:** published supplements such as LoreSmyth's *Wondrous Expeditions: Forests* and the D&D *Dungeon Master's Screen: Wilderness Kit* provide expedition and travel mechanics that could be mapped onto real trail days.

8. Where The Quest is distinctive

- **Real journey as game structure:** actual distance, terrain, weather and fatigue serve as the campaign's travel mechanics.
- **Single continuous arc:** one story across a multi-day expedition, rather than one-shots or daily sessions.
- **Character formation framing:** explicit roots in wilderness ministry and moral imagination.

Practical challenges to plan for: insurance and liability, wilderness-certified staff (first aid, trip leading), and finding a game master who can also lead outdoors, or pairing a game master with a trip leader.

Note: details such as prices and dates come from the linked public listings and may have changed; verify with each provider.

Part II: Detailed Report on Contacts, Insurance and Advisors

This part adds who runs each program, how to reach them, what is publicly known about insurance, and who would be worth asking for advice before piloting The Quest. None of the programs publish their insurance arrangements, so the insurance section covers the specialty insurers that serve this field and the questions to ask each operator.

9. Program contacts and organizational profiles

9.1 Renaissance Adventures (Boulder, Colorado)

Item	Detail
Address	5717 Arapahoe Ave., Suite 100, Boulder, CO 80303 ("Burning Tree" business park, across from the Flatirons Golf Course entrance)
Phone	(303) 786-9216
Fax	(303) 786-9217
Founder and Director	Mark Hoge
Business Manager	Aaron Pirnack (per BBB profile)
Founded	1995
Legal entity	Renaissance Adventures, LLC

Profile: Mark Hoge founded Renaissance Adventures in 1995 after years in the summer camp industry. He is an Eagle Scout and drew on Scouting and live-action role-playing. It began as a small after-school enrichment program in Boulder and grew into camps, birthday parties and afterschool programs across the Colorado Front Range and other states. He studied at Naropa University. The organization says it keeps groups very small and trains its staff carefully. It describes the skills it builds as critical thinking, teamwork, ethical reasoning and conflict resolution. Its proprietary "Adventure Quest" game system blends role-playing rules with live action.

Why contact them: Hoge's mix of Scouting, camp leadership and LARP is the closest existing match to your plan to pilot The Quest with a Scout den. He has run this model for about 30 years.

Links: Contact page · About page · Homepage · Mark Hoge on LinkedIn · BBB profile

9.2 The Story School (Charlton, Massachusetts)

Item	Detail
Camp address	Nature's Classroom, 73 Pumpkin Ln, Charlton, MA 01507
Phone	781-214-1174 (Laura Hall)
Executive Director	Christopher (Chris) Wiley
Director	Laura Hall (also listed as Laura Hall-Gosenca)
Status	Educational nonprofit; listed in the American Camp Association camp finder
Founded	2013; original Camp FABLE and Camp Grimoire programming since summer 2022
Scale	About 80 overnight campers per session in 2026, up from 40 total in 2021
Price range	$1,800 to $3,800, depending on camp and length; scholarships and sibling discounts

Profile: Chris Wiley grew up in Alabama and moved to Boston, where he worked as a special education teacher and as an actor and stage combatant. He has 20 years as a professional actor and teacher and 15 years in educational LARP. He describes the aim as helping campers "level up" through autonomy, progress and belonging. The camp ties STEAM lessons to in-game power: campers earn strength points and magical abilities by completing lessons. The organization emphasizes inclusion of neurodiverse youth. Wiley and Hall presented "Learning Through LARP" at the American Camp Association New England conference.

Why contact them: They know how to tie learning goals to game mechanics in an overnight setting, and they work within the ACA camp-standards world.

Links: Contact page · Staff page · About page · Camp page · ACA camp listing · Chris Wiley on LinkedIn · Blog

9.3 Dust and Tribe (Southern California)

Item	Detail
Legal entity	Dust and Tribe, LLC
Founder	Ahmed Pierstorff
Area	Cerritos, Southern California
Founded	Informally earlier; formally 2012

Item	Detail
Other staff	Anas Amer, adventure lead and US Forest Service rangeland technician; newer leaders Luke, Andrea and Todd
Channels	Website contact form, Discord, YouTube, podcast; deliberately avoids social media
Motto	"Progressio quolibet veniet" ("progress through whatever comes")

Profile: Dust and Tribe calls itself "the original Muslim Adventure Community." It frames wilderness experience as spiritual formation, so it is the clearest example of a faith-based outdoor ministry using D&D. Pierstorff is a registered nurse with training in psychiatry, addiction medicine, end-of-life care, chronic disease management and wilderness first aid. He first camped in his early twenties and found it deeply healing. The group grew from informal plant-identification walks into organized hikes and weekend camping trips. It has partnered with Islah Academy, a school built on experiential learning. A 2024 post announced a transition in how events are run.

Why contact them: They are the best model for the ministry and character-formation framing, and for running a D&D night inside a faith-based outdoor community.

Links: Contact page · About Us · D&D Campout event · Voyage LA interview with Ahmed Pierstorff · Podcast · YouTube · Events update, 2024 · Islah Academy partnership

9.4 American Youth Foundation, Camp Miniwanca (Michigan)

Item	Detail
Main phone	231-861-2262
Executive Director of Miniwanca	Griffin Vogler
Director of Outreach	Bethany Wise, bwise@ayf.com
Director of Adult Programs	Holley Young, hyoung@ayf.com
Client Relations Manager	Sara Umland, 231-861-2262 ext. 1113
Other leadership	Sandra George (Girls Camp Director); Brianna Moynihan (Director of Program Operations)
Status	Nonprofit foundation; donations offset the price of every program

Profile: The AYF is a long-running youth character and leadership organization. Griffin Vogler joined in 2020 after 10 years in the senior healthcare industry. One finding matters a lot

for The Quest. Miniwanca's "Four Trails" program already runs real multi-day expeditions. For example, its Adventurer program has campers entering grade 10 canoe the Au Sable River toward Lake Huron, camping out each night (a three-week session was listed at $5,150 in 2024). Together with the Boys Camp LARP and D&D program, that means AYF already runs both halves of The Quest, though separately.

Why contact them: They could tell you how a character-formation organization structures expeditions, and whether they have ever thought of combining the expedition and role-play programs.

Links: Our Team · Staff spotlight: Griffin Vogler · Summer Camp FAQ · Adventurer expedition program · 2026 Camper and Family Handbook (PDF) · LARP and D&D article

9.5 Strathcona County (Alberta)

No named staff contact was found in this search. Open question: who coordinates the Nature's Quest D&D week? The county recreation registration pages are the starting point: Week 3 listing.

10. How insurance is handled

Short answer: None of the five programs publish their insurance arrangements. A dedicated niche of LARP insurers does exist, though, and the standard package they sell is an **accident medical policy plus a general liability policy**, bundled annually.

10.1 Why insurance matters for this kind of program

Rookie Insurance sums up the risk: participants can get hurt, families may have limited medical coverage or high deductibles, and game masters can face personal exposure to lawsuits. Venues and landowners also often require proof of liability coverage. Westpoint Insurance notes that most LARP injuries happen during staged battles, which matters if The Quest uses foam-sword combat. An expedition adds trail, water, weather and vehicle risks on top of that.

10.2 Specialty insurers

Provider	What they offer	Link
Anthony Insurance Services	Accident and liability policy for LARP clubs and events; optional coverage for rented, borrowed and non-owned vehicles; excess liability limits	LARP insurance · Policy details · Cost and coverage explained
Rookie Insurance	LARP accident and liability coverage; online application with same-day quotes	LARP insurance
Francis L. Dean & Associates (F. Dean)	Specialty LARP program covering medical costs and liability	Brochure (PDF) · LARPfinder summary
World Events Specialty	Specialty program for LARP organizations covering lawsuits and participant injury claims	LARP program
Chalmers Insurance Group	General camp insurance with risk-management services and 24/7 claims	Camp insurance

Background reading: Atlas Obscura on the quest for LARP insurance · Money on LARP insurance

10.3 What this means for a Scouting pilot

If the pilot runs as an official den or pack activity, Scouting America's own unit coverage and safety rules may apply instead of a separate policy. This was not verified in this search. Confirm with your local council before planning, especially whether a hired outside game master counts as covered, and whether foam combat and bikepacking are approved activities for your son's age group. A later MIHLab-run version of The Quest outside Scouting would need its own accident and liability coverage from a provider like those above.

10.4 Questions to ask each operator about insurance

1. Do you carry a LARP-specific policy or a general camp policy, and through which broker?
2. Does your accident medical coverage pay first or after the family's own insurance?
3. How are foam-weapon combat and off-site trail activities covered?
4. Are contracted game masters or actors covered, or must they carry their own coverage?
5. What do landowners, parks or host camps require from you?
6. What waivers do you use, and has your lawyer reviewed them for minors?

7. Did ACA accreditation or other standards change your premiums or requirements?

11. People to ask for advice

Person	Organization	Best for	How to reach
Mark Hoge	Renaissance Adventures	Running the live game master role; Scouting-to-LARP crossover; moral dilemmas in play	(303) 786-9216; contact page
Chris Wiley	The Story School	Linking learning goals to game mechanics; overnight eduLARP; staff training	Contact page; LinkedIn
Laura Hall	The Story School	Camp operations, registration, ACA standards	781-214-1174
Ahmed Pierstorff	Dust and Tribe	Faith-based wilderness formation; wilderness first aid; running D&D on campouts	Contact page
Griffin Vogler	AYF Miniwanca	Character-formation expeditions plus LARP/D&D within one organization	231-861-2262
Bethany Wise	AYF Miniwanca	A first point of contact at AYF	bwise@ayf.com
Your local Scouting council	Scouting America	Pilot approval, coverage, leader training, transferring your Missouri den leader certification	Your council office

11.1 Suggested questions for an advice conversation

1. How do you keep the story going when the group is tired, cold or split up?
2. What staff-to-youth ratio works for live role-play outdoors?
3. How do you hire and train game masters, and what do you pay them?

4. Have you ever run a quest across a multi-day route rather than at a fixed site?
5. How do you build in moral dilemmas without preaching?
6. What has gone wrong, and what would you do differently?

12. Limits of this report

- Contact details come from public web listings and may have changed; confirm before reaching out.
- No operator's actual insurance carrier or policy was found; Section 10 describes the market, not their arrangements.
- Strathcona County staff contacts were not found.
- Scouting coverage details were not verified.

Part III: Filling the Gaps

This part answers the open questions left in Part II: the Scouting rules, Strathcona County contacts, the smaller programs, staffing and pay, and safety and waivers. **The most important finding is that Scouting America's Guide to Safe Scouting prohibits LARP-style combat.** A Scouting pilot of The Quest must use non-contact role-play.

13. Scouting America: rules that shape a pilot

13.1 LARP combat is a prohibited activity

The Guide to Safe Scouting's activity planning section lists prohibited activities. They include "activities where participants strike at each other, including martial arts, boxing, combat games, gladiator games, and reenactment activities such as live action role-playing games (LARP) and Society for Creative Anachronism (SCA) activities." It also prohibits activities where participants shoot or throw objects at each other, such as dodgeball or sock fights.

What this means for The Quest: foam-sword fighting between Scouts is out. Story, characters, puzzles, negotiation, riddles, map work and dice-resolved "combat" told at the campfire all remain open. That actually suits a tabletop D&D style better than a boffer LARP style.

Source: Guide to Safe Scouting, Activity Planning and Risk Assessment

13.2 Insurance coverage through Scouting

Coverage	What it does	Source
General liability, registered adults	Primary liability coverage for registered volunteers and professionals for claims arising from an official Scouting activity	GSS Insurance
General liability, unregistered volunteers	Excess (secondary) coverage only	Montana Council explainer
Charter organization coverage	Commercial general liability including excess auto liability; written at $7.5 million per occurrence and $20 million aggregate in the current charter agreement	Annual Charter Agreement (PDF)
Accident and sickness	Many councils cover youth and registered adults for injuries on official outings (confirm your council's plan)	Crossroads of America example
Certificates of insurance	Councils can issue certificates naming parks or landowners as additional insured; facility contracts need careful review	Certificates of Insurance

A hired game master is a vendor. Scouting America's Youth Protection FAQ says third-party vendors don't have to register, but "must be licensed businesses that carry proper liability insurance." Supervision stays with the unit leaders. So a hired DM should have their own business and liability policy, or should register as a Scouting volunteer instead. Source: Youth Protection FAQs

13.3 Leader requirements and transferring your registration

- **Safeguarding Youth training** is required for all registered volunteers and must be renewed every year. Source: Youth Protection
- **The 72-hour rule:** any adult who spends 72 or more total hours with a unit on Scouting activities must register, with a background check and youth protection training, even if they're a parent. A multi-day Quest could trigger this for a hired DM. Source: Registration Guidebook (PDF)
- **Transferring your registration:** adults transfer themselves in my.scouting.org through the "My Applications" tab. You don't need a new application, but you must answer the youth protection questions again. Sources: Transfers and Multiples job aid (PDF) · Service Center FAQ

- **Supervision:** two-deep adult leadership is required.

13.4 Bikepacking and backpacking in Scouting

- Full high-adventure trekking (three or more consecutive nights in the wilderness, including backpacking and mountain biking) is aimed at older Scouts, not Cub Scouts. Source: Guide to Safe Scouting (PDF)
- The Cub Scout Cycling adventure already includes planning and riding a 10-mile route with a patrol, pack or family. That makes it a natural first leg for a mini-Quest. Source: Cycling adventure
- Check the age-appropriate activity guidelines before choosing a format. Source: Age-Appropriate Guidelines (PDF)

14. Strathcona County contacts

Item	Detail
Venue	Strathcona Wilderness Centre, 52535 Range Road 212, Ardrossan, Alberta
Program questions	780-922-3939 · swcinfo@strathcona.ca
Recreation, Parks and Culture	780-467-2211
Facilities	Year-round walk-in tent sites (groups up to 60), a rustic cabin and bunkhouses; bookings 48 hours ahead

No named coordinator for the D&D week was found. Ask the program line for whoever designs Nature's Quest.

Links: Outdoor pursuits programs · Wilderness Centre · Camping

15. The smaller programs: contacts and details

Program	Key details	Contact
Epic Quest / D&D Camp (Eugene, OR)	Ideas came from tween and teen campers. It blends D&D with wilderness skills, using "the natural world all around you as the material of your live action D&D quests." Campers choose race, class and background, and also do river time and carving. Very close to The Quest in spirit.	Operator not named in the listing; see 2025 listing
Heroes Academy, LARP Adventure Program (Massachusetts area)	Created by director Eric Love. Mixes theater, martial arts and prop design. Overnight events keep a strict 1:10 counselor ratio, nearer 1:5 in practice. Staff are background-checked and paid staff need First Aid/CPR/AED.	Website · Curriculum · St. John's camp
Pali Adventures (Southern California)	ACA-listed overnight camp. LARP is a half-day specialty with ongoing D&D games, and campers build their own boffers.	909-867-5743 · Contact · LARP page · ACA listing
Waynflete D&D Maine Adventure Camp (Portland, ME)	Covered in Section 6. No director name found.	Camp page
Cincinnati Parks D&D Nature Camp	Covered in Section 6. No named staff found.	Event page
Boardwalk Board Game Lounge (Peterborough, ON)	Co-owner Dylan Reinhart, who has an outdoor educator background.	Article
Camp Starfish LARP Week	A specialty program that may go off-site for adventures, at a 1:3 staff-to-camper ratio.	LARP Week

16. Staffing: ratios, pay and training

16.1 Ratios

Source	Recommended staff-to-youth ratio
Guardian Adventures (UGS Lite LARP guidance)	1:5 ages 4–5; 1:6 ages 6–7; 1:8 ages 7–10; 1:10 ages 11–15; 1:15 ages 16+
LARP Adventure Program overnights	1:10 required; about 1:5 in practice
Camp Starfish LARP Week	1:3 (off-site adventures)

For an expedition, the lower end of these ratios is safer, because the group is spread out on trail and far from help.

16.2 Pay

Renaissance Adventures posted starting pay of $15.50–$17 an hour for Quest Leaders plus a $150 end-of-summer bonus, $18–$19 an hour for Site Supervisors, $24 an hour for weekend parties, and mileage at 50 cents a mile. These figures come from an older job listing. Source: Salary.com listing

The Story School pays by experience for a 9-week season, with room, board and paid training. Source: Employment

Open question: no going rate was found for a professional freelance DM hired for a multi-day trip. Ask the advisors in Section 11.

16.3 Training and hiring

- **Renaissance Adventures:** applicants interview with Mark Hoge and one or two managers. Paid training starts with video and reading, then two weeks in person in late May, covering First Aid and CPR, working with children, conflict resolution, inclusivity and emotional safety, and running Adventure Quest. All staff are background-checked. Source: Colorado employment
- **Guardian Adventures** says that experience gaming with adults doesn't carry over to running games for children. It recommends child-centred training, role-played scenarios such as a shy or dominating child, and safety drills. Its free UGS Lite system gives camps a ready-made LARP framework. Sources: How to staff a children's LARP · Free LARP game for camps
- **Link to The Story School:** Chris Wiley discovered educational LARP through Guard Up, the company behind Guardian Adventures.

17. Safety, waivers and foam weapons

17.1 Foam weapon standards (outside Scouting only)

Across LARP groups the common standards are: a PVC, fiberglass or carbon-fiber core; at least 5/8 inch of closed-cell foam around it; foam extending at least 1 inch past each end of the core; and a soft open-cell thrusting tip of 2–3 inches, so the core can't be felt. Groups inspect weapons at check-in, ban strikes with the flat or the pommel, and require checking for damage before each use.

Sources: Xadune · Mythic Adventures · Citadel LARP · Underworld LARP guide (PDF)

These apply only to a non-Scouting version of The Quest (Section 13.1).

17.2 Waivers and medical

- No program published its waiver. Ask for a sample when you contact them (Section 10.4).
- Scouting outings use the Annual Health and Medical Record. Some activities require a physician's health history, so check which part applies to the trip length.
- Staff in the programs reviewed hold at least First Aid and CPR. For a backcountry Quest, Wilderness First Aid is the usual expectation (Ahmed Pierstorff of Dust and Tribe holds it).

18. Updated limits of this report

- Each operator's insurer and policy is still unknown; only Scouting's coverage is documented.
- The going rate for a freelance multi-day DM is still unknown.
- Epic Quest Camp's operator wasn't identified.
- The Scouting details come from national documents; your Florida council may add its own rules.
- Some details come from search summaries rather than full pages; confirm prices, dates and names before relying on them.

Part IV: Creative Design

This part has two halves. Section 19 describes how existing programs design their stories and game systems, with sources. Sections 20 to 26 are original design proposals for The Quest itself. They are starting points to test and revise, not findings.

19. How existing programs design stories and game systems

19.1 Renaissance Adventures: Adventure Quest

- **Archetypes and powers:** participants pick mythic archetypes and powers, then band together to defend a village, solve a mystery or negotiate a peace treaty.
- **Small parties:** groups of about six, so every child gets a turn to "shine and be the hero."
- **Planned social learning:** social and emotional learning is built in, and "many of the plot points are planned to develop the participants' social skills."
- **Challenge types:** riddles, map reading, puzzling dilemmas, negotiation and swordplay.
- **Supporting materials:** the trademark list in its parents' guide names a Journeybook, a quest-leading workshop and three levels of "Inspiring Invitations" (details not public). The guide also mentions an "Asking for Help" talk.
- **Tailoring:** quests are adjusted to the goals and needs of each group.

Sources: Adventure Quest program · Tour of Adventure Quest · Homeschool programs blog · 2017 Parents' Guide (PDF)

19.2 The Story School: Camp FABLE and Camp Grimoire

- **Story sources:** each world draws on real history, mythology and literature, so campers "live out a story they will read about in school."
- **Learning drives power:** campers earn strength points and magical abilities by completing STEAM lessons, then use them against monsters.
- **Three strands:** story carries content; leveling up requires STEM skills; role-play teaches social and emotional skills.
- **Mix of challenges:** foam battles, puzzles woven into the story, and escape-room-style challenges.
- **Older campers:** Grimoire raises the difficulty for teens with fiercer monsters, harder puzzles and more "cerebral" challenges.

Sources: Homepage · Camp page · Worcester Central listing

19.3 Østerskov Efterskole (Denmark): a whole school taught through larp

- Teaching is organized as multi-week projects, each with a narrative storyline binding the activities together, rather than subjects.
- The school year cycles through narrative weeks, test and project weeks, and exam preparation.
- Academic content becomes a practical problem in the story: a spaceship's navigation computer fails, and the only way to plot a course is to solve a differential equation.
- Students may add their own plot points, in the Nordic larp style.

- Research (Gjedde, 2013) found that some students are motivated by the emotional story and others by strategy and competition. Design for both.
- Contact: kontor@osterskov.dk · +45 7734 2990 · Kirketoften 4, 9500 Hobro, Denmark.

Sources: Nordic Larp Wiki · Learning by Playing · RPG Research profile · Middle-school edu-larp study

Two Nordic design ideas worth borrowing. First, power between adults and children has to be designed on purpose. If it isn't, out-of-game social power carries straight into the game. Second, designing "for hope, agency, and inclusion" with young players. That second idea is closely aligned with MIHLab's moral-imagination-and-hope focus. Sources: Power dynamics between adults and children · Nordic Larp tools

19.4 Hero's-journey rite-of-passage programs

These programs share The Quest's character-formation goal, though not its game layer.

Program	Design pattern	Link
Hero's Journey at The Hole in the Wall Gang Camp	Seven-day wilderness program for ages 16–18, explicitly built on Joseph Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, framed around "What's next?"	ACA research article
Journeymen Triangle, Rites of Passage Adventure Weekend	Follows the hero's journey arc: an invitation ("Are you ready to enter the world of men?"), wilderness challenge, letting go, then return "with new eyes and a new name"	Program page
The Heroic Journey (school curriculum)	Year-long staged program; a "passport" is stamped as each stage of the journey is completed	FAQ · Program
Rite of Passage Journeys (Pacific Northwest)	Backcountry trips for ages 10–12 with trail games, campfire stories and songs	Call to Adventure
True North Journeys	Hero's Journey rite of passage for boys 14–17	Program

19.5 Common patterns across all of these

1. A small party (about six) with one guide.
2. Real-world skill turned into in-game power.
3. Social and moral dilemmas planned into the plot, not left to chance.
4. Physical tokens of progress, such as a journal, a passport or abilities.
5. A departure-and-return structure that ends in recognition.

20. The Quest: core design concept

Proposal: the real route is the story map. Each physical stretch of trail is a region of the world, each campsite is a settlement or refuge, and the trip's actual hardships (climbs, rain, fatigue, a broken chain) are the travel events. Nobody pretends to journey. They really journey, and the story explains why.

Design principles

1. **The body earns, the story pays:** real effort and real Scout or trail skills unlock in-game abilities, adapting The Story School's STEAM-points model.
2. **Moral choices have weight:** every chapter contains at least one dilemma with no clean answer, building on Renaissance Adventures' planned dilemmas.
3. **Hope is the destination:** the arc ends in repair or restoration, not just victory, in keeping with MIHLab's emphasis on hope.
4. **Conflict through words, wit and dice:** no physical striking. This suits Scouting rules (Section 13.1) and keeps attention on moral imagination.
5. **Everyone shines:** each character has a moment designed around their strengths.

21. World and story frame

Three sample premises, each built to fit a route with a start, a hard middle and a destination:

- **The Lamplighters.** The lanterns along an old road have gone dark, and the villages between them have stopped trusting one another. The party carries the last flame to relight each lantern (each campsite). At every village they must restore some broken trust before the lantern will catch. Theme: hope as something carried and shared.
- **The Cartographers' Guild.** The great map of the realm was torn, and the pieces are scattered. The party travels to recover them, and each fragment comes with a moral riddle about what the map should show and who it leaves out. Theme: seeing truly, and the ethics of representation. This fits well with philosophy content.

- **The Pilgrims of the Spring.** A drought has struck the land, and the party journeys to a distant spring to ask why. At the end they learn the drought is tied to choices the villages made, and the "cure" is a change of heart they must carry home. Theme: responsibility and return. It suits the wilderness-ministry framing.

22. Campaign structure mapped to the trip

Trip stage	Hero's journey stage	Game content	Formation focus
Gathering (before departure)	Call to adventure	Character creation; the commission; packing as "provisioning"	Choosing who you want to be
Day 1, first miles	Crossing the threshold	Leaving the known lands; a gatekeeper character tests the party's resolve	Courage, commitment
Middle days	Trials and allies	Regions with puzzles, travelers in need, rival parties, negotiations	Cooperation, honesty, mercy
The hardest day (biggest climb or longest ride)	The ordeal	The story's crisis lands on the real hardest stretch	Perseverance, caring for the weakest member
Destination	The reward	The goal is reached, and with it a revelation that changes the meaning of the quest	Humility, insight
Return	Return with the gift	Bringing the gift home; each character is recognized	Service, gratitude

Nightly rhythm: a short campfire session each evening resolves the day's events with dice, introduces the next region and closes with reflection. The trail days run in light live-action mode, with scenes at planned stops.

23. Game mechanics

Character sheet: a simplified one-page sheet with a name, an archetype, three virtues the player chooses to grow, two special abilities and a short backstory.

Sample archetypes: Pathfinder (navigation), Healer (first aid), Keeper of Lore (knowledge and riddles), Quartermaster (food and gear), Herald (negotiation and speech), Warden (protecting the group). Each one maps to a real responsibility on the trip, so the role is both a fiction and a job.

Real skills earn in-game power:

Real-world action	In-game reward
Navigating a leg correctly by map	The Pathfinder gains a "True Path" ability
Fixing a flat or adjusting a bike	Earns a "Tinker's Mark" usable to repair a story artifact
Pitching camp as a team in a set time	The party's refuge is "warded" for the night
Cooking the group meal	Restores the party's "Heart" points
Helping a struggling member	Earns a virtue token (see below)

Virtue tokens: adults award physical tokens (for example, carved wooden discs or bead colors) for observed acts of courage, honesty, kindness or perseverance. Tokens can be spent in the story for rerolls or special help. They also become keepsakes of the trip, playing a role like The Heroic Journey's stamped passport.

Conflict resolution: dice decide outcomes in the campfire sessions. On the trail, "encounters" are riddles, negotiations with characters played by staff, team challenges and moral choices. Nothing involves striking or throwing at people.

Journey journal: each youth keeps a small in-character journal of what happened, what they chose and why. It is the reflection tool, and a natural place for the faith or character-formation layer (a nightly question, a verse or a maxim).

24. Moral dilemma bank (samples)

1. **The Shortcut:** a stranger offers a route that saves half a day but crosses land the party was asked not to enter. (Honesty, keeping promises)
2. **The Slow Traveler:** an injured character (played by staff) needs escort, and taking them means missing a deadline in the story. (Mercy versus duty)
3. **The Shared Water:** the party finds a spring, and a rival party arrives just as thirsty. (Justice, generosity)
4. **The False Credit:** the village elder praises the wrong party member for a deed. (Humility, truthfulness)
5. **The Ancient Law:** a village rule seems cruel, but breaking it would cause harm the party can't see. (Respect, moral uncertainty)
6. **The Tired Friend:** in the real world, one member is struggling. The story offers an in-game reward to the group that waits for and supports them. (Care for the weakest)

Each dilemma ends with a short debrief question at the campfire: "What did your character value in that moment? What would you do?"

25. Roles and staffing for the story

- **Game master:** runs the story, plays key characters, adapts on the fly.
- **Trip leader:** owns safety, route, weather and timing, with authority to pause the game.
- **Character actors (optional):** volunteers or parents placed at checkpoints to play travelers, villagers or gatekeepers. Within Scouting, adults present 72 or more hours must register (Section 13.3).
- **The "pause" signal:** a clear, agreed word or gesture that stops the game for safety or comfort. Anyone, youth or adult, may use it.

Safety tools from tabletop gaming: session zero (agreeing on tone and limits before play), an "X-card" style signal to skip content that makes someone uncomfortable, and lines and veils (topics left out, or kept offstage).

26. Pilot design: a one-day den Quest

A sample first test for your son's den, within Scouting rules.

Premise: *The Lamplighters*, one lantern only.

Time	Activity
Morning, at the meeting place	Quick character creation (archetype, name, one virtue); the commission from the "Lantern Warden"
Trail stop 1	A riddle at a bridge or trail junction, solved by the Keeper of Lore with the group
Trail stop 2	A "wounded traveler" (a parent in costume) needing first aid, which ties to a real Cub Scout skill
Trail stop 3	A dilemma: a shortcut with a hidden cost
Lunch	The "Quartermaster" serves; the party's Heart is restored
Final stop	Relighting the lantern (a safe battery lantern or supervised fire if permitted) after the group recalls one act of kindness from the day
Closing	Virtue tokens awarded; each Scout says what their character learned

What to observe: engagement levels, which stops worked, whether the story helped or hurt pacing, how parents responded, and whether the reflection felt natural or forced. Those observations become the case for a longer overnight or bikepacking version.

Note: Sections 20 to 26 are proposals for discussion and testing, not tested practices.

Part V: Certifications for Running The Quest Yourself

To act as both game master and wilderness guide, the certifications that add the most legitimacy are, in order: **wilderness medicine (WFA, then WFR)**, **Leave No Trace**, **Scouting outdoor training**, a **cycling instructor credential** for bikepacking, and optionally a **game master facilitation** credential. Core wilderness credibility takes about two to four weeks of total course time, spread over a year.

27. Wilderness medicine

This is the most important credential. Parents, insurers and land managers look for it first.

Certification	Length	Approx. cost	Who it fits	Where
Wilderness First Aid (WFA)	16 hours over 2–2.5 days	About $325	Trips where emergency help can arrive in under about 8 hours; camp staff; weekend trips	NOLS WFA · Midwest Outdoor Skills Training schedule
Wilderness First Responder (WFR)	70–80+ hours, usually 9–10 days	About $935 (one NOLS listing)	The standard for professional trip leaders; primary responder in remote emergencies	NOLS WFR · Landmark Learning WFR
Hybrid WFR	30–40 hours online, then 5 days in person	Varies	Same as WFR, with half the in-person time	NOLS Hybrid WFR
WFR recertification	24 hours over 3 days (2 days hybrid)	From about $390 at NOLS	Keeps the WFR current before it expires	Cost and length guide

Certification	Length	Approx. cost	Who it fits	Where
CPR/AED	Often an optional evening add-on to WFA	Varies	Required by most programs alongside first aid	Usually bundled with WFA

Other providers include SOLO, Aerie and Wilderness Medical Associates (WMA). Compare levels on the NOLS course comparison chart and the full NOLS course list.

Recommendation: WFA is enough to start the den pilot. WFR is the professional standard for running multi-day backcountry trips yourself.

28. Leave No Trace

Level	Length	What it lets you do	Where
Awareness workshop	One day or less	Basic introduction	LNT trainings
Skills course	At least 8 hours (up to 16)	Learn and practise the skills	LNT trainings
Level 1 Instructor (formerly "Trainer")	2 days	Teach Leave No Trace skills and ethics to groups	LNT instructor courses
Level 2 Instructor (formerly "Master Educator")	5 days and 5 nights in the field, ages 18+	Highest common level; can teach Level 1 courses	LNT Master Educator · NOLS course · Scouting America version

Scouting America runs its own Level 2 course, and some councils split it over two weekends (example).

29. Scouting America outdoor training

These count for the den pilot in particular.

Course	Length	Why it matters	Where
Safeguarding Youth (Youth Protection)	Online, renewed yearly	Required for all registered leaders	Safeguarding Youth

Course	Length	Why it matters	Where
BALOO (Basic Adult Leader Outdoor Orientation)	1.5 days: an online prerequisite plus an overnight practical	Required for at least one adult on any Cub Scout pack overnight	Adult Leader Training · Longhouse Council summary
IOLS (Introduction to Outdoor Leader Skills)	Hands-on weekend-style course (length varies by council)	Outdoor skills for Scouts BSA (troop) leaders; required for troop direct-contact leaders	Cascade Pacific Council summary

Access these through my.scouting.org and your local council's training calendar. In Florida, check the council that covers DeLand.

30. Cycling and bikepacking instruction

Certification	Length	Focus	Where
League Cycling Instructor (LCI)	3-day seminar, after passing the free Smart Cycling Complete Course (about 4.5 hours online, with a score of 85% or higher)	Road and traffic cycling safety; teaching children and adults	League of American Bicyclists · Seminar description (PDF)
PMBIA Level 1 Mountain Bike Instructor	3 days plus 2–3 hours of pre-course work (27 hours total, including assessment)	Teaching beginner to low-intermediate off-road riders	PMBIA Level 1
PMBIA kids module	1 day	Adapting lessons and bike setup for children by age group	Ninja Mountain Bike Skills

Recommendation: for bikepacking on mixed roads and trails with youth, pair LCI (road safety) with PMBIA Level 1 and the kids module (trail skills).

31. Outdoor leadership and camp administration

Credential	What it is	Where
WEA Certified Outdoor Leader (COL)	Wilderness Education Association professional credential for outdoor leaders	WEA COL
WEA Certified Outdoor Educator (COE)	Recognizes knowledge and experience in outdoor education and leadership	WEA COE
WEA Outdoor Leadership Training Course (OLTC)	Field-based leadership training course	WEA OLTC
ACA Camp Director Certificate	Online course in camp basics for directors with fewer than six years' experience	ACA certificate

Lengths for the WEA courses and the ACA certificate weren't listed in the search results; check each page.

Note: ACA says a certification alone isn't enough. Employers must also verify that staff can perform site-specific skills. Source: ACA certification resources

32. Game master and role-play facilitation

No general "certified game master" credential exists. The established ones come from therapeutic role-play.

Credential	Length and format	Notes	Where
Game to Grow, Certified Therapeutic Game Master	Three levels, completed within five years; Level Two is a 7-hour live virtual training	Game to Grow doesn't require a clinical licence for certification; on-demand tracks are aimed at mental health professionals	Game to Grow training · STAR Institute series · Certified GM directory
Therapeutic Game Master course	9-week "minimester", 36 continuing-education hours	Covers ethics, facilitation and intervention design	therapeuticgamemaster.com
Geek Therapeutics TGM Certification	Online, self-paced	Open to mental health professionals, educators and group facilitators	Geek Therapeutics

A caution: these credentials are built around therapy. They can sharpen your facilitation skills, but The Quest shouldn't be marketed as therapy unless a licensed clinician is involved. Your existing qualifications (a PhD in philosophy, teaching ethics and logic, instructional design) are probably stronger legitimacy for the *educational and moral-formation* side than any GM certificate.

33. Suggested pathway and timeline

Phase	Credentials	Approx. time
Now (before the den pilot)	Transfer Scouting registration; Safeguarding Youth; BALOO; WFA with CPR	About 4–5 days total, plus online modules
Within 6 months	Leave No Trace Level 1 Instructor; League Cycling Instructor	About 5–6 days total
Within 12 months	Wilderness First Responder (or hybrid)	9–10 days (or 5 days plus online)
Optional, year 2	PMBIA Level 1 and kids module; LNT Level 2; WEA credential; Game to Grow levels; ACA Camp Director Certificate	Several weeks spread over the year

Beyond certifications: running trips yourself as a business may also need land-use permits from the agencies managing your routes (for example, commercial-use permits on public land), plus the insurance in Section 10. Check with each land manager before charging for trips. This wasn't researched in detail here.

Part VI: Accreditation and Compliance for a Business

For an organization offering The Quest, two voluntary accreditations add the most legitimacy: **American Camp Association (ACA) accreditation**, which explicitly covers travel and trip programs, and **Association for Experiential Education (AEE) accreditation for adventure programs**. In Florida, the legal requirements are mainly Level 2 fingerprint background screening, a Department of Health permit if you operate a fixed camp site, and land-use permits for public lands. Florida does not license guides.

34. Voluntary accreditations

34.1 American Camp Association (ACA)

- **What it is:** ACA says it is the only national accrediting body for camps of all types. Its standards focus on health, safety and risk management, and government agencies use them as benchmarks.
- **Fit for The Quest:** ACA accredits day and resident camps, **travel and trip programs**, school and environmental education programs, and camps with special emphases, including religious ones.
- **Process:** a written self-assessment against the standards, then an on-site visit during operation. Some standards are mandatory. Applications must arrive by **February 1** for a visit that summer. The accreditation year runs November 1 to October 31.
- **First season:** a camp can be visited in its first season, but it isn't accredited until all criteria are confirmed.
- **Cost and time:** annual fees on a sliding scale by location. One industry estimate puts initial fees at $500 to $1,200 or more, with 40 to 80 hours of self-assessment work in the first year.
- **Standards book:** the *ACA Accreditation Process Guide* (2025 standards).

Links: Program overview · Accreditation · Getting started · Camps seeking accreditation · Standards at a glance · Cost · Site-visit timeline · Process Guide · Jumbula cost estimate

34.2 Association for Experiential Education (AEE)

- **What it is:** since 1994, AEE's accreditation has been the industry's accepted standard for experiential and adventure programs, built on risk-management, ethics and quality standards and assessed by independent reviewers.
- **Two tracks:** *Adventure Programs* (the right fit for The Quest) and *Outdoor Behavioral Healthcare* (for programs with licensed therapists; not The Quest).
- **Process:** you study the standards manual, apply, host a site visit by peer reviewers, and the AEE Accreditation Council votes on accreditation.
- **Local note:** AEE is headquartered at 2315 18th Street South, St. Petersburg, FL 33712 · 303-440-8844, so it's in your own state.

Links: About accreditation · Adventure program standards · Application and documents · Why choose an accredited program · One organization's path to accreditation

34.3 Which to pursue

Factor	ACA	AEE
Best known to	Parents, schools, camp industry	Outdoor and adventure education field, universities
Fit	Youth camps and trip programs	Adventure and experiential programs
Timing	Apply by February 1 for a summer visit	Rolling process with peer review
Practical first step	Join ACA, attend the free "getting started" webinar	Buy and study the adventure standards manual

One option is to build operations to ACA standards from the start, because parents recognize it, and to add AEE once the program has a record.

35. Florida legal requirements

Requirement	What applies	Source
Camp permit	ACA's state summary lists a Department of Health license for day and resident camps, under the recreational camp rule (Fla. Admin. Code 64E-15). It mainly covers fixed sites (water, sewage, sanitation). Ask the county health department whether a mobile trip program needs one.	ACA Florida regulations · DOH recreational camp permits
DCF childcare licence	Summer camps aren't licensed by the Department of Children and Families	DCF summer camp page
Background screening	Fingerprint-based Level 2 screening for adults with direct contact with minors, renewed under current law, with records kept for at least five years (confirm which statute applies to your program type)	VolunteerBadge Florida camps · Protect My Ministry · Volunteer screening guide

Requirement	What applies	Source
Guide licensing	Florida "does not license or permit guides nor have minimum requirements for them"	FWC Outfitters & Guides
Federal land permits	Commercial guides and outfitters generally need a permit to operate on federal lands; rules vary by agency	Congressional Research Service report
State parks	Contact each park; the statewide line is 850-245-2157	Florida State Parks FAQ

Because Florida doesn't license guides, voluntary accreditation and staff certifications (Part V) are the main public proof of competence.

36. Business structure and other credentials

- **Legal entity:** MIHLab is already a Florida LLC. A nonprofit (a 501(c)(3) or a fiscally sponsored program) would open grant funding and church or Scouting partnerships, and is common among programs like AYF and The Story School. Discuss this with an attorney or accountant; this isn't legal or tax advice.
- **Insurance:** see Section 10. Accreditation bodies and land managers will ask for certificates of insurance.
- **Written policies:** emergency action plan, risk-management plan, incident reporting, health forms, youth protection policy and staff code of conduct. Both ACA and AEE review these. AEE publishes incident-data templates on its documents page.
- **Staff credentials:** maintain a staff file with each person's first aid, WFR, LNT and screening dates (Part V).
- **Partnerships:** running early trips under an already-accredited partner (a church camp, council or ACA camp) can lend legitimacy while you build your own record.

37. Suggested business pathway

Phase	Steps
Year 1 (pilots)	Run pilots through Scouting, under its insurance and rules; set up Level 2 screening; draft written safety policies; join ACA as a member

Phase	Steps
Year 2 (first independent trips)	Get insurance (Section 10); land permits; check with the county health department about permits; build the program to ACA standards
Year 2–3	Apply for ACA accreditation (by February 1); consider a nonprofit arm
Year 3+	Pursue AEE adventure-program accreditation

Not legal advice. Confirm Florida requirements with the Department of Health, the FDLE and an attorney before operating.

Part VII: Family Programs

The Quest is meant for parents and children to take part together, not as a drop-off program. This part surveys family and parent-child programs in the same depth as Part I. **No program found combines a family expedition with a continuous story campaign.** The closest pieces are a Unitarian Universalist family LARP weekend that keeps one storyline running year to year, and several faith-based parent-child backpacking trips with nightly discussion and blessing rituals.

38. Family role-play programs

38.1 Camp de Benneville Pines: LARPing, Misty Mountain Adventure (California)

Why it matters: the closest family match to The Quest's game side. It's a family camp weekend of live and tabletop role-play, run by a faith-based camp.

Item	Detail
2026 dates	Friday, August 14 – Sunday, August 16, 2026
Dean (session lead)	Bill Damerell
Format	"A fantasy-themed mountain adventure for all ages": live-action and tabletop role-playing, archery, crafts, quests, foam-weapon fighting, swimming
Continuity	The 2025 session was "Misty Mountain Wars Year Two", so the story world carries over from year to year

Item	Detail
Setting	Rustic cabins in the San Bernardino Mountains near Jenks Lake
Address	41750 Jenks Lake Rd W, Angelus Oaks, CA 92305
Phone	(909) 794-2928
Executive Director	Janet James · director@uucamp.org · 909-435-6298
Affiliation	Unitarian Universalist camp, open to "UUs and kindred spirits"; 65th anniversary in 2026
Registration	Through the Bunk1 family portal

Philosophy: the camp describes itself as a place for families "to spend quality time together and renew their bonds," free of "constant electronic noise," where "people of all ages rediscover the joy of personal interaction."

Gap relative to The Quest: a fixed base camp over a weekend; the journey is imaginary.

Links: 2026 Misty Mountain Adventure · 2025 Misty Mountain Wars Year Two · Camp homepage · Contact info (via Camp Transcend page) · Yelp listing · Family portal

Contact for advice: the session dean, Bill Damerell, through the camp office. He has run a multi-year family LARP storyline, which is the closest experience to what The Quest proposes.

38.2 Camp D&D: Family Camp (international)

- An organization offering "transformative experiences in a safe and natural environment," built around social-emotional growth, experiential learning and "authentic coexistence."
- Its method follows a process of "awareness, appreciation" (the description was cut off in the search results).
- Its Family Camp aims to "rekindle the core of life: the family."
- Details on dates, location and price weren't in the search results. The name suggests a role-play link, but this wasn't confirmed.

Links: Camp D&D · Family Camp

38.3 Other family-inclusive gaming events

- **James Reed Camps, "I Don't Wanna Grow Up" kids camp:** parents are "absolutely welcome (and encouraged) to participate." Website

- **D&D in a Castle (Tabletop Vacations):** a four-day adult retreat with more than 24 hours of play led by a professional DM. It's adult-only, but a useful model for a premium, multi-day, single-campaign format. Website
- **Dungeons & Cabins:** an all-inclusive adult D&D summer camp, which shows there's adult demand for camp-style gaming. Website

39. Faith-based parent-child wilderness trips

39.1 Voice of Wilderness, with the Faithful Fathering Initiative (Colorado)

Why it matters: the closest match to The Quest's wilderness-ministry framing. These are parent-child backpacking trips with a structured nightly program on faith and character.

Item	Father-Son Adventure	Father-Daughter Adventure
2026 dates	June 14–20, 2026	June 7–13, 2026
Ages	Son at least 14	Not stated in results
Route	Trail into the Weminuche Wilderness, along streams and waterfalls up to high lakes in the San Juan Mountains; five days on trail	An overnight backpack to a meadow in the Weminuche, with exploring and a campfire cookout
Ending	Soak at Pagosa Springs hot springs, then a mountain feast at the lodge "recounting the adventures of the past week"	Hot springs, then back to the lodge; each dad blesses his daughter on the last evening (per Faithful Fathering)
Skills	Teamwork, map and compass, setting up camp, fishing	Exploring the forest
Cost (most recent listed)	$725 per person, $150 deposit, balance due by May 5 (listing shows 2022 figures)	Not stated in results

Program content: Faithful Fathering "guide[s] this trip and facilitate[s] structured discussion time each evening around specific manhood topics and scripture," with the aim to "raise the bar" for the parent-child relationship.

Base camp: Mountain Light Lodge, the company's lodge on 35 acres north of Pagosa Springs at about 9,400 feet. It's surrounded by San Juan National Forest, about five minutes from the Weminuche Wilderness boundary, and has a large open fireplace. The lodge rents to groups of up to 15.

Links: Father-Son Adventure · Father-Daughter Adventure · About our trips · Lodging · Mountain Light Lodge · Lodge about page

39.2 Faithful Fathering Initiative in Texas (the partner ministry)

Item	Detail
Founder and President	Rick Wertz (since 2000)
Chairman	Brenden R. O'Neill
Status	Nonprofit; files IRS Form 990 (EIN 76-0658211)
Mailing address	P.O. Box 1702 (Texas)
Email	admin@faithfulfathering.org
Next father-daughter trip	June 6–12, 2027
Other retreats	Father-son "Adventures for Life" weekends and father-daughter "Being There" weekends for dads with teenagers

Founder background: Rick Wertz has a mechanical engineering degree from the University of Kansas (1980). He worked at Schlumberger from 1980 to 1995, ending as country manager in Norway. He took graduate study in the Dimensions of Fathering at Abilene Christian University and trained with the National Center for Fathering. He has been married 45 years, with three children and four grandchildren.

Model: a church-based strategy called **PASS the BATON**. *Purpose-filled fathers* (a core group of committed dads), *Activities* for dads and kids that are fun and have a spiritual element, *Studies* for dads, and *Staying connected* through one-on-one time such as retreats and adventures. Churches receive a binder and a relay baton to start a fathering movement. Endorsed by Memorial Drive Presbyterian Church, Houston.

Why contact: Wertz has run faith-based parent-child adventure retreats for over 25 years and built a model that churches adopt. That's directly relevant if The Quest is offered through churches.

Links: Homepage · Retreats & Trips · Who We Are · Contact · PASS the BATON · GuideStar profile

39.3 Blueprint for Men: Father-Son Rite of Passage (Wyoming)

- **Trip:** a 7-day backpacking trip in the Wind River Range of Wyoming.
- **Provided:** trip leadership, naturalist education and spiritual guidance. Participants bring their own camping equipment.

- **Cost:** $300 per dad, covering shared expenses.
- **Larger framework:** a *Manhood Rite of Passage* at age 16, run over **7 weeks with a cohort of 4 father-son pairs** in four steps. It's built on Luke 2:52 ("Jesus increased in wisdom and stature, and in favor with God and man": mind, body, spirit) and ends in a blessing ("This is my beloved Son in whom I am well pleased").
- **Design note:** the cohort of four families meeting over several weeks before and after the trip is a strong model for The Quest. It would let the story start before the trail and continue afterward.

Links: Father-Son Rite of Passage · Manhood Rites & Blessings (PDF)

39.4 Other faith-based parent-child programs

Program	Details	Link
Sons of Men Rite of Passage Camps	Father-son camps for sons aged 7–13, equipping them "to embrace their God-designed" identity; the age range matches Cub Scouts	Father-Son Camp
Mountain Gateway Rite of Passage	Father-son backpacking for sons aged 12–14; campsite selection, route finding, navigation and time alone with God	Rite of Passage
BraveCo Rite of Passage	Father-son event for sons aged 14–19	Rite of Passage
Hume Christian Camps, Father Son Adventure Camps	Adventure camp for men and boys	Hume

40. Secular parent-child and family programs

40.1 Rites of Passage Institute (Byron Bay, Australia)

Camp	Pairing	Ages
Young Stars	Parent and child	7–11
Father & Daughter	Father and daughter	Girls 7–11 (e.g., Aug 20–22, 2027)
Mother & Daughter	Mother and daughter	Not stated in results

Camp	Pairing	Ages
Mother & Son	Mother and son	Boys 10–13 (three 2027 dates)
Making of Men	Father and son	Boys 14–17 (5-day camps, three 2027 dates)

- **Price:** $1,750 per listing (probably Australian dollars; the Young Stars range goes up to $3,950). A full camp kit is provided.
- **Format:** two- to five-day camps; "every Parent and Child camp runs the same 2-day program" core, with an indoor fallback for wet weather.
- **Purpose:** to help the parent and child "connect, bond, and mark a meaningful threshold together" as the child moves into adolescence or adulthood.
- **Also offers:** a 3-day training in its Rites of Passage Framework, online or in person, which could be relevant training for you.
- **Contact:** an online camp inquiry form, with replies within two business days.

Links: Parent & Child Camps · Homepage · Mother & Son · Father & Daughter · Making of Men · Young Stars · Camp inquiry

40.2 Inner Guide Expeditions

- **Father-Son Adventure:** 6 days and 5 nights in two "chapters": backpacking first, to build wilderness skills and self-reliance, then canoes delivered for the second half.
- **Custom Family Expeditions:** trips designed with each family, from US backpacking to kayaking in Baja, the Tour du Mont Blanc, the Boundary Waters, or New Zealand.
- **Pre-trip design process:** several conversations to decide the focus ("a certain dynamic that needs to be highlighted? A challenge? Simply to connect and have fun?"), with interviews of each family member and, optionally, people outside the family.
- **Origin:** the founder started it after a month-long guided trek around Mont Blanc in summer 2024.
- **Design note:** interviewing each family member beforehand is a useful model for building each family's characters and story threads.

Links: Father-Son Adventure · Custom Family Expeditions · Homepage

40.3 Back To Earth: Parents' Passage (California)

- An Eastern Sierra backpacking trip for adults, July 31 – August 5, 2026, for parents whose sons have gone through Back To Earth's youth rite of passage.
- Camping in a meadow along Buckeye Creek, ending each day with "food, songs, and stories by the fire."

- The idea: "By stepping into the mountains yourselves, you help strengthen that circle of recognition for your children and for one another."
- **Design note:** this treats parents as people on their own journey, not just chaperones, which is relevant to The Quest's family model.

Link: Parents' Passage

40.4 YMCA Adventure Guides (various US YMCAs)

- A long-running national-style YMCA program in which parent-child groups (traditionally father-son and father-daughter) follow the school year, from late August to late May or early June, with one big event a month.
- Parents "lead, direct, influence and teach," and the program builds community among families with children of the same age.
- YMCA of Orange County runs named "expeditions" (father-daughter, father-son, parent-child), with goals including "expands awareness of spirit, mind, and body" and the motto that "the Family is True North."
- **Design note:** the year-long, recurring structure is the closest existing model for a Quest "season" made of several trips. You don't have to be a YMCA member to join.

Links: YMCA of Silicon Valley · Greater Seattle-area YMCA · YMCA of Orange County

40.5 Camp Mondamin: Father-Son Weekend (North Carolina)

- Only one guardian may attend, with boys only. A separate Friends and Family Weekend is offered for whole families.
- An in-camp option in a private 750-acre wilderness area ("the Back Forty") with an easy mile-long approach hike and tents or open-air shelters.
- An out-of-camp option: an overnight backcountry trip (backpacking, canoeing or climbing) that is more physical, with participants carrying their own packs.
- **Design note:** offering an easier and a harder track within one family weekend is a good way to handle mixed fitness levels.

Link: Father-Son Weekend

41. Comparison of family programs

Program	Pairing	Length	Moves through wilderness?	Story/game?	Faith framing	Cost listed
Camp de Benneville Pines LARP	Whole families, all ages	Weekend	No (base camp)	Yes, multi-year storyline	Unitarian Universalist	Not stated
Voice of Wilderness	Father-son or father-daughter	7 days	Yes (backpacking)	No	Christian (scripture)	$725/person (2022)
Blueprint for Men	Father-son, cohort of 4	7-day trip; 7-week rite	Yes	No	Christian	$300 per dad
Rites of Passage Institute	All four parent-child pairings	2–5 days	No (camp)	No	Secular	$1,750 (likely AUD)
Inner Guide Expeditions	Father-son; custom family	6 days	Yes (backpack + canoe)	No	Secular	Not stated
YMCA Adventure Guides	Parent-child	School year, monthly	Some events	No	Y's spirit-mind-body	Varies
Camp Mondamin	Father-son	Weekend	Optional	No	Not stated	Not stated
The Quest (proposed)	**Whole families**	**Multi-day**	**Yes (bike/backpack)**	**Yes, one campaign**	**Character / ministry**	**One family price**

42. What the family programs teach for The Quest's design

1. **Rituals of blessing and recognition** (Voice of Wilderness, Blueprint for Men) fit naturally at the end of the campaign, when each character is recognized by their own parent.
2. **Nightly structured discussion** (Faithful Fathering) maps onto the campfire debrief after each day's dilemma.
3. **Cohorts of about four families** (Blueprint) suit both trail logistics and a D&D party size.
4. **Before-and-after sessions** (Blueprint's 7 weeks, YMCA's school year) would let character creation start at home and the story's "return" continue after the trip.

5. **Parents as participants on their own journey** (Back To Earth) suggests giving parents real characters and roles, not just supervision.
6. **Two difficulty tracks** (Camp Mondamin) handle mixed ages and fitness.
7. **Pre-trip family interviews** (Inner Guide) help the game master write each family's story threads.
8. **A continuing world** (Camp de Benneville's "Year Two") gives families a reason to return each year.

42.1 Family-specific design proposals for The Quest

These are proposals, not findings.

- **Parent and child as linked characters:** each pair shares a bond in the story (mentor and apprentice, or siblings-in-arms), so some challenges need both of them.
- **Role reversals:** at least one scene where the child leads and the parent follows, such as the child navigating while the parent carries the map case.
- **Separate then reunite:** a short stretch where parents and children solve parallel halves of a puzzle, then meet to combine their answers.
- **The blessing scene:** at the destination, each parent names a virtue they saw in their child during the journey, using the virtue tokens from Section 23.
- **Per-family pricing:** one price per family unit (for example, up to two adults and two children, with an add-on for extra children). That keeps the focus on the family rather than on headcount.
- **Scouting fit:** Cub Scouts is already family-based, so the den pilot naturally tests the family model.

43. People to ask for advice (family programs)

Person	Organization	Best for	How to reach
Bill Damerell	Camp de Benneville Pines (session dean)	Running a multi-year family LARP storyline for all ages	Via the camp office, (909) 794-2928
Janet James	Camp de Benneville Pines (Executive Director)	Family camp operations	director@uucamp.org · 909-435-6298
Rick Wertz	Faithful Fathering Initiative	Faith-based parent-child retreats; church partnerships; blessing rituals	admin@faithfulfathering.org

Person	Organization	Best for	How to reach
Voice of Wilderness staff	Voice of Wilderness / Mountain Light Lodge	Running parent-child backpacking trips	Website
Blueprint for Men leaders	Blueprint for Men	Cohort-based rite of passage design	Event page
Inner Guide founder	Inner Guide Expeditions	Custom family expedition design and pre-trip interviews	Website
Rites of Passage Institute team	Rites of Passage Institute	Parent-child rite-of-passage framework; offers a 3-day training	Camp inquiry form

44. Limits of this section

- Some prices are out of date (Voice of Wilderness shows 2022 figures), and some currencies are unclear (Rites of Passage Institute).
- Camp D&D's family camp details and its link to role-play weren't confirmed.
- None of these programs publish insurance details, and family-program insurance (adults as participants) wasn't researched separately.
- Details come mostly from search summaries; confirm them on each program's pages.

Part VIII: Certification Bundles and Florida Partners

Short answer: no single "Quest leader" certification bundle exists. Two providers come close by offering wilderness medicine and Leave No Trace under one roof: **Landmark Learning** and **NOLS**. In Florida, the strongest partner options near DeLand are the **Central Florida Council of Scouting America** (which covers Volusia County and runs its own Wilderness First Aid courses), the **Florida Trail Association**, and the state's **youth conservation network**, which has 300+ partners and its own funder.

45. Certification bundles and one-stop providers

Provider	What it bundles	Notes	Link
Landmark Learning (North Carolina)	NOLS WFA, WFR, Hybrid WFR and recertifications; Wilderness EMT; Leave No Trace Level 1 (including hybrid) and Level 2; Wilderness Swim Safety; American Canoe Association courses	Named a Leave No Trace Gold Standard Program in 2026; college credit and financial aid; Landmark Scholars program	Homepage · Outdoor instructor courses · All courses
NOLS	Wilderness medicine (WFA to WEMT) plus LNT Level 1 and Level 2 instructor courses	NOLS founded the Leave No Trace program; LNT Level 2 offers 2 college credits and accepts AmeriCorps education awards; NOLS also runs **family trips for children aged 10 and up**	Course list · LNT Level 2 · LNT providers
Scouting America (through your council)	Youth Protection, BALOO, IOLS, Wilderness First Aid and LNT courses, often at low cost	The most practical "bundle" for the den pilot	Central Florida Council events

Practical bundle for you: a Landmark Learning or NOLS WFR combined with an LNT Level 1 course in one trip, plus Scouting training through the Central Florida Council. That covers most of Part V in two or three blocks of time.

46. Wilderness First Aid courses in Florida

Provider	Details	Link
Central Florida Council (Scouting America)	16-hour WFA courses with online prework; a fall 2026 session's registration closes October 26, 2026	Fall WFA · 16-hour WFA
The FOLC Farm	WFA, WFR and CPR courses in Florida; also outdoor-skills workshops for adults and kids. Upcoming dates include June 5–6, 2027 (Oct 24–25, 2026 sold out)	Remote medical · Homepage
Hike It Florida	Two-day WFA courses taught around Florida	WFA
Feral Human Expeditions	SOLO-accredited instructors for WFA and WFR	Classes
Florida Heartsaver	SOLO Wilderness First Aid	SOLO WFA
The Wildlife Society, Florida Chapter	WFA and CPR, 2 days, $495 including meals (Jan 20–21, 2026 at Wakulla Springs Lodge)	Event
American Red Cross	Wilderness and Remote First Aid classes	Red Cross

47. Florida partner organizations

47.1 Central Florida Council, Scouting America (your home council)

- **Coverage:** Orange, Osceola, Seminole, Lake, Brevard, **Volusia** and Flagler counties, which includes DeLand.
- **Headquarters:** Apopka, just north of Orlando. Office hours are 8:30 a.m. to 5 p.m. on weekdays.
- **Main camp: Camp La-No-Che** in Paisley, next to the Ocala National Forest. It runs high-adventure programs for older Scouts, winter camps, and an International Jamborette in July 2027.
- **Local:** Cub Scout day camps have been held at 509 E Pennsylvania Ave, DeLand.
- **Districts:** monthly roundtables and district committee meetings (such as the Timuqua and Seminole districts) are where a pilot idea could be pitched to other leaders.
- **Why partner:** insurance, trained leaders, a camp next to Ocala National Forest, and a ready-made audience of families.

Links: Council website · Event registration · Calendar · Camp La-No-Che · Unit Annual Planning Guide (PDF) · Wikipedia

47.2 Florida Trail Association (FTA)

- A 501(c)(3) volunteer nonprofit that builds, maintains and promotes the 1,500-mile Florida National Scenic Trail, in partnership with the US Forest Service.
- **18 local chapters**, including a Central Florida chapter.
- Works regularly with **youth, corps, university and affinity groups**. The contact for those partnerships is the Community Outreach Manager.
- **Membership** starts at $40 a year, and some land-management units require it to cross their land. There's a $10 youth membership for ages 18–30.
- Hosts **Florida Trail FEST**, a free festival with guided hikes and workshops on the Suwannee River.
- Has co-run multi-day backcountry benefit hikes with other organizations (for example, a 3-day, 2-night trip with Loggerhead Marinelife Center).
- **Office:** 1022 NW 2nd St, Gainesville, FL 32601 · 1-877-HIKE-FLA
- **Why partner:** route knowledge, land-manager relationships, a trail-service angle for character formation, and a co-hosting model.

Links: Homepage · Our Partners · Chapters · Trail FEST · USFS partnerships · Thru-hiker guide (PDF)

47.3 Florida Youth Conservation Centers Network (FYCCN) and its funder

- **FYCCN** is part of the Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission. It's a network of **300+ public and private partners**, including parks, community centers, camps, clubs, museums and zoos.
- It runs conservation summer camps in Apollo Beach, Brooksville, Lakeland, Ocala, Tallahassee and West Palm Beach. One sleepaway camp serves ages 9–17, with programs from about $400.
- **Fish & Wildlife Foundation of Florida** calls itself Florida's largest private funder of youth outdoor education, and it works closely with FYCCN. **It's a possible funding source.**
- FWC also runs family-oriented youth hunts and outdoor-skills programs with volunteer mentors.

Links: FYCCN · FYCCN summer camps · Fish & Wildlife Foundation youth programs · FWC youth programs

47.4 Family-focused and outdoor-skills partners

Organization	What it offers	Partnership angle	Link
Florida Adventure Club	Statewide family learning network visiting public lands	Has an explicit "Partner With Us" invitation for curriculum alignment, co-promotion and family events	Partner page
Uncle Dave's Central Florida Survival School	Hands-on Florida wilderness and primitive-skills courses, just north of Orlando; run by David Rose, a former Recon Marine and certified Master Naturalist	Skills instruction or guest "sage" character on a Quest	Website
The FOLC Farm	Outdoor skills and wilderness medicine for adults and kids	Training venue; family workshops	Website
Florida Paddling Trails Association	Taylor Howard Youth Paddling Fund: grants that help send children to paddling camps (about $200 per child per week)	Scholarships for a paddling version of The Quest	Youth programs
Pathfinder Outdoor Education	Nonprofit since 1993 "building personal, social and environmental responsibility through the power of shared experience"	Shared mission (it appeared in Florida search results; confirm its location)	Website
Camp Impact	A Central Florida Christian camp	Faith-based host site	Blog post

47.5 Cycling and bikepacking partners

Organization	What it offers	Link
Florida Bicycle Association	Statewide cycling safety education and a network of qualified instructors since 1987; guidance for parents on youth cycling	Programs · Homepage
Bike Florida	Promotes bike tourism and runs tours for beginners and enthusiasts	Website
Singletrack Samurai Productions	Florida bikepacking events, including a Suwannee River Valley dirt-road tour (Dec 4–6, 2026) and the Cross Florida time trial	Website
Bikepacking.com Florida routes	Route library including the 1,144-mile Florida Divide (Tallahassee to Key West)	Florida routes

48. Partnership models

These are options to consider, not findings.

1. **Scouting-hosted pilot:** run the first Quests as Central Florida Council den or pack events, under its insurance and rules, and possibly at Camp La-No-Che or in the Ocala National Forest.
2. **Co-hosted trips:** you design and run the story; a partner (the Florida Trail Association, a trained outfitter or a camp) supplies the route, permits, safety staff or site. This is the Voice of Wilderness and Faithful Fathering model from Section 39.
3. **Hosted by a camp:** run The Quest as a specialty family weekend at an accredited camp, the way Camp de Benneville Pines hosts its LARP weekend. That borrows the camp's accreditation and insurance.
4. **Church partnership:** offer The Quest through congregations, using a church-adoption model like Faithful Fathering's PASS the BATON.
5. **University partnership:** Stetson University, your current employer, could co-sponsor it as community engagement, a research site (moral imagination, game-based pedagogy) or a student-leader program. Not researched here.
6. **Funding partners:** the Fish & Wildlife Foundation of Florida and the Florida Paddling Trails Association's youth fund are possible sources of scholarships or grants.

49. Suggested first contacts in Florida

Contact	Why	How
Central Florida Council training and program staff	Pilot approval, WFA and BALOO courses, camp use	cflscouting.org
Your district roundtable (Volusia)	Recruit other dens and leaders	Council calendar
Florida Trail Association Community Outreach Manager	Route and partnership for a youth or family hike	Our Partners · 1-877-HIKE-FLA
Florida Adventure Club	Family audience and co-promotion	Partner page
Fish & Wildlife Foundation of Florida	Funding	Youth programs

Details come from public listings and search summaries; confirm dates, prices and contacts directly.

Part IX: The Subcontracting Model (MIHLab as Game Master Only)

50. The model

MIHLab markets the program and runs the story. Jim acts only as the game master. An established outfitter or program is the operator of record and supplies certified guides, first aid, gear, permits, camping logistics and insurance. This model is common in outdoor travel, and several Christian outfitters below already run custom trips for outside groups such as churches, youth groups and families.

Two ways to set it up:

1. **The partner sells, MIHLab adds the story.** Families book and pay the outfitter directly, and MIHLab is hired as a specialty add-on. This has the lightest legal and insurance load for MIHLab.
2. **MIHLab sells, the partner runs the trip.** Families pay MIHLab, which pays the outfitter. MIHLab keeps the brand and the customer relationship, but takes on more liability and may trigger Florida's seller-of-travel law (Section 52).

51. Contract checklist

These are items to discuss with an attorney, not legal advice.

- A written agreement that splits the duties. The outfitter handles safety, medical care, routes, permits, staffing ratios and the go/no-go decisions. MIHLab handles the narrative and the game.
- **Guides' safety authority always overrides the story.** The game pauses whenever a guide says so.
- MIHLab is named as an **additional insured** on the outfitter's liability policy, and the outfitter provides a certificate of insurance.
- MIHLab still carries **its own general liability policy**, and possibly professional liability, as the game master.
- Waivers come from the operator, and MIHLab is named in them as well.
- Indemnification runs both ways, each party covering its own negligence.
- Background checks for anyone with direct contact with minors, including Jim (see Section 36).
- Rules on cancellations, refunds, weather and emergencies.
- Ownership of intellectual property: the campaign, characters and materials stay MIHLab's.
- Pricing: a per-family price that combines the outfitter's fee and MIHLab's fee.

52. Florida seller-of-travel law

- Florida requires anyone who sells or promotes travel-related services to **register annually with the Florida Department of Agriculture and Consumer Services (FDACS)**, unless exempt.
- Registration for sellers that don't offer vacation certificates takes a **$300 fee and a surety bond of up to $25,000**.
- Nonprofits are **not automatically exempt**. Anyone claiming an exemption must get a letter of exemption from FDACS.
- **Open question:** whether a guided camping trip that MIHLab resells counts as "travel-related services." Model 1 above (families pay the outfitter directly) may avoid the question entirely. Confirm with FDACS or an attorney.

Links: FDACS Sellers of Travel · Who must register · Exemptions · Nonprofits · Registration package (PDF)

53. Possible operating partners in Florida

Partner	What they provide	Fit	Link
Hike It Florida	Guided hiking, camping and backpacking; private trips; children's camps; classes including WFA	**Strongest Florida fit:** it already runs private custom trips	Website
Not a Clue Adventures	Guided hiking and backpacking in Central Florida	Possible local guide service	Guided trips
Juniper Springs outfitter (Ocala National Forest)	Paddling logistics on Juniper Run through the Juniper Prairie Wilderness	Paddling version of The Quest	Florida Hikes overview
Uncle Dave's Central Florida Survival School	Florida wilderness skills instruction	Skills guide on the trip	Website
Buck Lake Group Camp, Ocala National Forest	Reservable primitive group camp for up to 50 people	A base site for a family Quest weekend	Recreation.gov · USFS

54. Christian outfitters

Outfitter	What they run	Where	Fit	Link
Advent Christian Village Conference & Retreat Center	Canoe and kayak outfitting; partners with the Suwannee River Wilderness Trail and the Florida Park Service	**Florida** (Suwannee River)	**The only Florida Christian option found**; a river-trip Quest	Outfitters page

Outfitter	What they run	Where	Fit	Link
Wilderness Trek	Christian backpacking since 1976; 5–6 day Group Treks for youth groups, families and teams; **custom family trips with a guide, all gear and meals provided**	New Mexico, Colorado, Utah	Strong fit for a flagship trip: they handle the whole trip	Website · Family adventures
Christian Adventures	Backpacking for outside groups: gear, permits, fees, meals and experienced leaders all provided	Check locations	**Explicitly operates for other groups' trips**	Backpacking
Covenant Pines Ministries	Guided family canoe trips for families of 4–8, aimed at a next step in faith	Minnesota	Family model	Family canoe trips
Solid Rock Outdoor Ministries	Climbing, backpacking and mountaineering focused on discipleship and leadership; individuals and groups, ages 13+	Check locations	Older youth	Website
Backcountry Sojourners	Christ-based nonprofit guiding men on expeditions to build character, faith and outdoor skills	Check locations	Mission match; men only	Website

Outfitter	What they run	Where	Fit	Link
Voice of Wilderness (see Section 39)	Father-son and father-daughter wilderness weeks	Colorado	Already partners with an outside ministry	See Section 39
Boundary Waters Outfitters	Not a ministry, but has dedicated packages for Scout and church groups	Minnesota	Self-guided outfitting only	Group packages

55. Questions to ask a prospective operating partner

1. Do you run custom trips for outside organizations, and can an outside game master run programming during the trip?
2. Who is the operator of record, and whose waiver do participants sign?
3. Can you name MIHLab as an additional insured, and what are your policy limits?
4. What certifications do your guides hold (WFR, WFA, LNT), and what staff-to-participant ratios do you use?
5. Are you accredited (ACA, AEE), and do you hold permits on public land?
6. How do you handle background checks for adults working with minors?
7. For faith-based outfitters: how flexible are your devotional or discipleship components, and could they be woven into the story rather than run separately?
8. What's your per-person or per-family rate for a 2–3 day trip, and what's the minimum group size?

Details come from public listings and search summaries; confirm everything directly. None of this is legal advice.

Part X: The Church-Ministry Model

56. How Faithful Fathering works with churches

- **Founder:** Rick Wertz, Founder and President, who has been doing this for 25+ years and is on the National Coalition of Ministries to Men speakers' bureau.
- **Core idea:** three marks of a faithful father: prioritize physical presence, engage emotionally, and lead spiritually by example.
- **PASS the BATON** is the church strategy. PASS stands for **P**urpose-filled fathering, **A**ctivities, **S**tudies and **S**taying connected.

- **How a church adopts it:** the church invites Rick Wertz to help start a "fathering movement." A **core group of dads** is trained, takes home a **binder of materials and a physical baton**, and commits to running the ministry in its own congregation.
- **Who runs the wilderness part:** Faithful Fathering doesn't run the trips itself. **Voice of Wilderness**, a separate outfitter, runs the father-son and father-daughter weeks (see Section 39).

Links: Faithful Fathering · Church strategy · PASS the BATON studies · In Group (binder and baton) · Start a fathering movement · Podcast episode with Rick Wertz · NCMM speaker profile

57. Applying the model to The Quest at a local church

These are options to consider, not findings.

- **Three roles:** the church hosts the ministry and recruits families; MIHLab (Jim) provides the story, game and leader materials; a wilderness operator runs safety and logistics.
- **Who could run the wilderness part:**
  1. **A contracted outfitter** (Sections 53–54). It has the most certifications and insurance, and it mirrors Faithful Fathering's arrangement with Voice of Wilderness.
  2. **Trained church volunteers** with WFA certification. Cheaper, but the church's insurer must approve it, and background checks are required.
  3. **Jim himself**, after the certifications in Part V. That gives him the most control but also the most liability.
- **Things to ask the church:** whether its insurance covers off-site overnight trips, its youth-protection and background-check policies, whether it requires its own waiver, and who on staff would sponsor the ministry.
- **A "baton" equivalent:** a leader kit with the campaign binder, story maps and virtue tokens, so each church's core group can run seasons on its own.

58. Launch plan: an outfitter first, then volunteers

- Hire an outfitter for the **first one or two trips**, then move to trained volunteers.
- Ask outfitters whether they'll **train volunteers on the job** during those first trips.
- First call: **Hike It Florida**, which runs private trips and teaches WFA. It doesn't publish prices for private trips, so ask for a quote. For comparison, other guided Florida day hikes cost about **$100–$125 per person**, with discounts for children; overnight trips with gear will cost more.
- A volunteer-run trip doesn't legally need an outfitter, since Florida doesn't license guides. The **church's insurer** decides whether volunteers alone are allowed.

59. Adventure Cycling Association: bikepacking outfitter and resource

- A member-supported nonprofit in **Missoula, Montana**, founded in 1973 as Bikecentennial. It has roughly 48,000–53,000 members and is the largest bicycle-travel membership group in North America.
- Runs **100+ guided tours a year**, publishes route maps (including the TransAmerica Trail, the Great Divide Mountain Bike Route and the new Golden Gravel Trail), offers bikepacking how-to guides, publishes *Adventure Cyclist* magazine, and advocates for safer cycling.
- **Possible roles for The Quest:**
  1. **Source of information:** route planning, gear and skills guides for a bikepacking version.
  2. **Possible outfitter:** its guided tours could host or model a Quest trip. Ask whether it runs custom or private group trips, or trips for families and youth.
  3. **Source of outfitters:** ask whether it can refer you to tour operators or route partners in Florida.
- **Unconfirmed:** whether it contracts with outside groups or sponsors other groups' trips. Ask through your membership.

Links: Homepage · About · Membership · Wikipedia

Part XI: Running Cost Tally

This is the master list of every possible cost for The Quest. Figures come from earlier sections where available; anything marked **quote** still needs a real number. Update this table as quotes come in.

#	Category	Item	Type	Known figure	Source / note
1	Trip operations	Outfitter or guide fees (first 1–2 trips)	Per trip	Quote. Guided Florida day hikes run about $100–$125 per person	Hike It Florida, §58

#	Category	Item	Type	Known figure	Source / note
2	Trip operations	Gear purchase or rental (tents, packs, bikes, stoves, water filters, bear-proof food containers)	Per trip or one-time	Quote	Ocala National Forest requires bear-proof food storage
3	Trip operations	Permits and campsite fees	Per trip	Quote	Buck Lake Group Camp (up to 50 people) on Recreation.gov
4	Trip operations	Food and water	Per person, per trip	Quote	
5	Trip operations	Transportation (vans, fuel, shuttles, bike transport)	Per trip	Quote	
6	Trip operations	First aid kits and supplies	One-time, then restock	Quote	
7	Trip operations	Emergency communication (satellite messenger, subscription)	One-time plus monthly	Quote	
8	Story and game	Game-master time (Jim)	Per trip	Set your own rate	No market rate found for freelance multi-day game masters, §10

#	Category	Item	Type	Known figure	Source / note
9	Story and game	Story materials: maps, journals, virtue tokens, props, leader kit or binder	Per family or one-time	Quote	§20–26, §57
10	Safety and people	Background checks (Florida Level 2, fingerprint-based)	Per adult	Quote	Required for adults with direct contact with minors, §36
11	Safety and people	Volunteer Wilderness First Aid	Per volunteer	About $325; $495 at the Florida Wildlife Society course with meals	§27, §46
12	Safety and people	Jim's Wilderness First Responder	One-time, plus recertification	About $935	§27
13	Safety and people	Leave No Trace training	Per person	Quote	§28
14	Safety and people	Scouting training (Youth Protection, BALOO, IOLS)	Per person	Usually low or no cost through the council	§29
15	Insurance	MIHLab general liability policy	Annual	Quote	§10, §51
16	Insurance	Professional liability for the game master	Annual	Quote	§51

#	Category	Item	Type	Known figure	Source / note
17	Insurance	Event or trip insurance, if church or outfitter coverage falls short	Per trip	Quote	Specialty insurers listed in §10
18	Legal and business	Attorney review of contracts and waivers	One-time	Quote	§51
19	Legal and business	Florida seller-of-travel registration	Annual	$300 fee plus a surety bond of up to $25,000	Only if MIHLab sells the trips, §52
20	Legal and business	Florida LLC annual report	Annual	Quote; confirm with Sunbiz	
21	Legal and business	ACA accreditation (later)	One-time plus annual	About $500–$1,200+ for initial fees	§34
22	Memberships	Florida Trail Association	Annual	From $40	§47.2
23	Memberships	Adventure Cycling Association	Annual	Already a member	§59
24	Marketing	Website, flyers, registration platform	Ongoing	Quote	
25	Reserve	Scholarships for families in need	Per trip	Optional	Possible offsets: Fish & Wildlife Foundation, FPTA fund, §47
26	Reserve	Contingency fund (weather cancellations, emergencies)	Per trip	A percentage of the budget	

How to use it: add up the per-trip rows and divide by the number of families to set a per-family price. Spread one-time and annual costs across the expected number of trips per year.

60. Per-person price worksheet (example)

These figures are placeholder assumptions, not quotes. Replace each one when real numbers come in, and the per-person totals will update.

Example trip: a two-day, one-night weekend with 12 participants (about 5 families) and 4 trips a year.

60.1 Per-trip costs

Item	Assumption	Trip total
Outfitter or guides	\$150 per person per day × 2 days × 12 people	\$3,600
Gear rental	\$25 per person	\$300
Permits and campsite	Flat	\$100
Food and water	\$40 per person	\$480
Transportation	Flat	\$200
First aid restock	Flat	\$50
Game-master fee (Jim)	Flat; set your own rate	\$500
Story materials	\$15 per person	\$180
Trip insurance	Flat	\$150
Subtotal		**\$5,560**
Contingency (10%)		\$556
Per-trip total		**\$6,116**
Per person (÷ 12)		**\$510**

60.2 Annual and one-time costs, spread across trips

Item	Assumption	Annual
MIHLab general liability	Estimate	\$600
Attorney review (first year)	Estimate	\$1,000
Jim's WFR	§27	\$935
Florida LLC annual report	Confirm	\$139
Florida Trail Association membership	§47.2	\$40
Marketing	Estimate	\$300

Item	Assumption	Annual
Annual total		**$3,014**
Per trip (÷ 4 trips)		**$754**
Per person (÷ 12)		**$63**

60.3 Suggested price per person

Phase	Per-trip share	Annual share	**Break-even per person**
With an outfitter (first 1–2 trips)	$510	$63	**$573**
Volunteer-run (no outfitter fee)	$180	$63	**$243**

Notes:

- Break-even already includes Jim's $500 game-master fee and a 10% contingency. Any profit or scholarship fund goes on top.
- The volunteer phase leaves out the outfitter but should add volunteer WFA and background checks once those quotes arrive.
- First-year attorney and WFR costs drop off in later years, which lowers the annual share.
- For a family price, multiply by family size or set a flat family rate. For example, a family of three at the outfitter phase comes to about $1,720.

61. Year-round model: weekend trips plus summer weeks (example)

These are placeholder assumptions, not quotes. The example year has **4 weekend trips** during the school year (2 days, 1 night) and **2 summer week-long programs** (6 days, 5 nights), each with 12 participants. That's 6 trips a year.

61.1 Summer week per-trip costs

Item	Assumption	Trip total
Outfitter or guides	$150 per person per day × 6 days × 12 people	$10,800
Gear rental	$60 per person per week	$720
Permits and campsites	Multiple sites	$300
Food and water	$120 per person	$1,440
Transportation	Flat	$300
First aid restock	Flat	$100

Item	Assumption	Trip total
Game-master fee (Jim)	Placeholder for a week	$1,500
Story materials	$25 per person (a fuller campaign)	$300
Trip insurance	Flat	$300
Subtotal		**$15,760**
Contingency (10%)		$1,576
Per-trip total		**$17,336**
Per person (÷ 12)		**$1,445**
Volunteer-run version (no outfitter): $4,960 + 10%		$5,456 → **$455 per person**

61.2 Annual costs spread across 6 trips

The $3,014 in annual costs from §60.2, divided by 6 trips, is about $502 per trip, or **about $42 per person**. Spreading fixed costs over more trips lowers the weekend price as well.

61.3 Break-even price per person

Program	With an outfitter	Volunteer-run
Weekend (2 days, 1 night)	**$552**	**$222**
Summer week (6 days, 5 nights)	**$1,487**	**$497**

61.4 Jim's game-master income in this example year

4 weekends × $500 + 2 summer weeks × $1,500 = **$5,000**, already included in the break-even prices.

Notes:

- Add volunteer WFA and background checks to the volunteer-run figures once quotes arrive.
- Summer weeks may count as a camp under Florida rules; see the open question about the DOH permit in §35.
- For comparison, Voice of Wilderness charged $725 per person for a week (2022 listing), and The Story School's overnight camps cost $1,800–$3,800.

Part XII: Marketing Strategy

Core message: a family wilderness adventure that unfolds as one continuous story, where parents and children grow in character together. No program found combines a family expedition with a continuous campaign (Section 38), so that is the selling point.

62. How comparable programs reach families

Program	How it reaches families	Lesson for The Quest
Faithful Fathering (PASS the BATON)	Churches invite the founder; a core group of dads takes a binder and baton home and runs it	Package The Quest as a ministry a church can adopt
Voice of Wilderness	Partners with an outside ministry that recruits fathers	Let a church or ministry recruit; MIHLab supplies the experience
Camp de Benneville Pines	An annual LARP weekend whose storyline continues year to year	A continuing story brings families back each season
YMCA Adventure Guides	School-year monthly events led by parents	A "season" model keeps families engaged between trips
Renaissance Adventures, The Story School	Market adventure role-play camps to parents on skills and growth	Lead with character and confidence, not just fun

63. Channels

Channel	Audience	Cost
Salty Church and other congregations	Christian families	Free
Central Florida Council (Scouts) roundtables	Den and pack families	Free
Florida Trail Association chapters	Outdoor families	Membership from $40
Homeschool groups	Families seeking enrichment	Free
Facebook Groups and church bulletins	Parents	Free
Short trip videos on YouTube	Prospective families	Free

Channel	Audience	Cost
Word of mouth from the pilot families	Friends and church members	Free

64. Pricing messages

- **One price per family**, so parents see it as a shared experience, not childcare.
- **Weekend:** about $575 per person with an outfitter, about $245 once volunteers run it (Section 60); price above break-even for scholarships.
- **Summer week:** about $1,490 per person with an outfitter, about $500 volunteer-run (Section 61).
- **Scholarships:** a fund or grant (Section 47) so cost doesn't exclude families.

65. Launch timeline (proposal)

When	Step
4–6 months before	Present The Quest Wilderness Ministry to Salty Church leaders; book an outfitter
3 months before	Recruit volunteers; start background checks and WFA training
2 months before	Announce in church, Scout roundtables and family groups
1 month before	Close registration; hold a family session zero
First trip	Film short clips and gather family quotes
After	Share the story; open the next season; invite other churches to adopt it